

A typical Keralan wayside shrine with offerings in the form of snake-stones.

What Nieuhof also remarked on was Nair arrogance, how they saw themselves as warriors and behaved accordingly, being ‘very haughty’ and refusing to ‘converse with any of the lower orders ... of which they are so cautious, that they will not so much as suffer any to approach them, for which reason, when they walk abroad they cry out aloud to the common people, “*Popoire*, keep back”, for if any of these should touch a *Nairos*, he would certainly ruin him.’

Nieuhof’s admiration was reserved for the Brahmins of the Malabar coast, who also considered themselves a class apart. ‘Among the several sects of the Malabars, that of the Brahmans is most reverenced,’ he noted, with undisguised approval.

> They are generally very wise, ready, active, modest and charitable, and strict observers of their promises. Some